# Ancient Japanese Communities Found Ways to Adapt After a Huge Eruption

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About 7,300 years ago, the Kikai-Akahoya volcano erupted beneath the sea near Japan. At that time, Japan was home to **Jomon** communities, people who lived by hunting and gathering. The eruption caused earthquakes and large waves and covered the land with thick **volcanic ash**.

For years, **archaeologists**, scientists who study past human life, have disagreed about what happened to the people living nearby. Some thought the people almost completely disappeared. Others thought some communities survived close to the disaster.

A new study led by Lund University in Sweden found that the real story was a mix of both. "The disaster caused major loss of life. However, survivors **migrated**, forged new social relations, innovated new kinds of economy," said lead author Enrico Crema of Cambridge University.

The researchers found that different regions responded in different ways. In southern Kyushu, an island in Japan, the **population** had already been shrinking before the eruption. In northern Kyushu, the **population** had been growing, and that growth continued afterward. People fleeing the worst-hit areas may have moved there. Survivors who lived inland also seem to have moved toward the northern coast, where sea life recovered quickly and provided food.

The team also found surprising changes far from the volcano. Places that had been growing before the eruption stopped growing or shrank afterward. The researchers say the eruption may have briefly disrupted the climate. Another possible reason is that deer and wild boar, important foods for the **Jomon**, may have worn down their teeth grazing on ash-covered land.

Professor Peter Jordan of Lund University said the study shows that even in very hard situations, communities "need to adjust, collaborate, and find new connections." The findings suggest a big disaster can affect people far beyond the place where it happens.

## Word Treasure

**archaeologists** -- Archaeologists are scientists who study how people lived long ago by examining the things they left behind.

**Jomon** -- The Jomon were ancient people of Japan who lived by hunting, fishing and gathering.

**volcanic ash** -- Volcanic ash is tiny pieces of rock and glass blasted into the air by an eruption.

**migrated** -- Migrated means moved from one place to live in another.

**population** -- A population is the number of people living in a place.

## Background you need

An undersea volcano erupts beneath the ocean, and a large one can cause earthquakes, huge waves and widespread ash.

Japan is a chain of islands, and Kyushu is one of its main islands in the south.

The Jomon were early people of Japan who lived by hunting, fishing and gathering, so damage to forests, animals and the sea directly affected their food.

Archaeologists estimate how populations rose or fell by studying the remains people left behind at many sites.

## Break it down

**LEAD:** A giant undersea eruption struck Japan about 7,300 years ago
**DEBATE:** did nearby people vanish or survive?
**KEY FINDING:** a mix of loss, migration, adaptation and growth
+- WHO: Lund University team; lead author Enrico Crema, Cambridge; Peter Jordan, Lund
+- SOUTHERN KYUSHU: population already shrinking before the eruption
+- NORTHERN KYUSHU: growth continued, helped by newcomers and recovering sea life
**SURPRISE:** distant regions stopped growing or shrank afterward
**POSSIBLE CAUSES:** brief climate disruption; worn teeth in deer and wild boar
**LESSON:** communities adjust and collaborate even after disasters

## Why it matters

The study shows that people can respond to a huge disaster in many different ways, and that a catastrophe can affect places far from where it strikes. Understanding this helps us think about how communities recover today.

## Test what you remember

**1. When did the Kikai-Akahoya volcano erupt?**

- (A) About 7,300 years ago
- (B) In 2022
- (C) About 730 years ago
- (D) About 73,000 years ago

**2. How did the Jomon people get their food?**

- (A) By trading with Europe
- (B) By hunting and gathering
- (C) By buying it in markets
- (D) By farming rice in big fields

**3. What did the new study find about the eruption's effects?**

- (A) Only animals were affected
- (B) There was a mix of decline, migration, adaptation and growth
- (C) Nothing changed
- (D) Everyone disappeared

**4. What happened to the population of northern Kyushu?**

- (A) It disappeared
- (B) It stayed exactly the same
- (C) It kept growing
- (D) It moved to Sweden

**5. Why might survivors have moved to the northern coast?**

- (A) There was no ash anywhere
- (B) Sea life recovered quickly and gave them food
- (C) The volcano was there
- (D) They wanted to build ships to leave Japan

**6. Which university led the study?**

- (A) MIT
- (B) Cambridge University
- (C) University of Plymouth
- (D) Lund University

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: D

## Questions to think about

**1. Lead author Enrico Crema: He says the disaster caused major loss of life, but survivors migrated, built new relationships and found new ways to live.**

**2. Professor Peter Jordan: He says even in very hard situations, communities need to adjust, collaborate and find new connections.**

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**